

Payment of rent

The same accounts in payment to the abbot of Chertsey for the land of Northwode at the feast of St Michael 6s. And in two ploughshares bought for payment to the same 18d. Sum 7s 6d.

Foreign expenses

The same accounts for the expenses of Richard Clerk, bailiff there, for his coming 2s 11d, by tally against the same. Sum 2s 11d.

Sum of all expenses 40s 7d.

And he owes £10 6s 3½d.

Rye

The same answers for 7 bushels of rye received from purchase as within. Of which in expenses of the lord's customary tenants mowing the demesne meadows and carrying hay ½ quarter by custom. In expenses of one boonwork 2 bushels by custom. Sold at the audit 1 bushel for 6d. Sum as above. And it equals.

Barley

The same answers for 1 quarter 7 bushels of barley bought for payments. Sum 1 quarter 7 bushels. And in payment of one hayward, who was hayward and carter from the fifth day of May until the feast of St Michael for 21 weeks, 1 quarter 6 bushels, taking a quarter for 12 weeks. Sold at the audit 1 bushel for 5d. And it equals.

From stock nothing this year.

25. c. 29 September 1320 to c. 29 September 1321

This account contains a wealth of unusual detail and brilliantly conveys the cumulative impact of the agrarian crisis of 1315–22. The effects of the cattle murrain are highlighted again, this time explicitly referring to the tenants' lack of draught animals. Nor was there any let up in the weather, for the hall at Kingston had recently been unroofed, perhaps as a result of the severe storms that wrought havoc elsewhere during the winter of 1320–21.⁴⁰⁹ We are left in no doubt about the impact of such conditions on demesne cultivation at Esher. Only 54 acres of land were sown, with no winter-sown crops at all being planted; this may well have been due to flooding, for very little land at Northwode was sown and oats, which are better able to withstand wet conditions, made up 94 per cent of the sown area. Although the impact on tenant livelihoods cannot be assessed with the same precision, two extraordinary details suggest that normal expectations of social behaviour were under intense pressure at this time: first, the bailiff was sent to deal with 'various men', apparently from outside the manor (although this does not necessarily mean they were from beyond Esher's boundaries), who were allegedly intent on inflicting damage and destruction on the bishop's property; secondly, presumably with manorial tenants in mind, the bailiff instructed a carpenter to construct a pillory, a cucking stool, and some stocks.

⁴⁰⁹ Kington, *Climate and weather*, p. 224.

Interestingly, too, the account hints at some of the strategies that were used to alleviate shortages of certain types of food by tenants and lord alike. For example, small willow withies were, for the first time, sold for making a fish trap, indicating a need to seek out alternative forms of protein. Indeed, preserved as well as fresh fish may have been consumed in unusually high quantities during these years: unlike the price of corn, the price of herrings remained remarkably stable, suggestive of an undiminished supply; and at 10 or more for a penny they would have been within reach of even the poorest in society. For the bishop, meanwhile, deficiencies in the local supply of meat and milk seems to have been met by the adoption of goat husbandry, with 115 goats sent up from Farnham, including 29 castrated males and 82 does.⁴¹⁰ In fact, despite problems with demesne resources, the bishop's lifestyle remained relatively unchanged by the events of the preceding few years. In this account we hear of him stopping off at Esher on his way to parliament in London and playing host to Hugh Despenser the Elder, who resided at Esher for three days; and while others may have been struggling with the cumulative impact of famine and murrain, the bishop's priorities appear to have included mending the door of his wine cellar at Esher.

HRO, 11M59/B1/76, *rot* 18r, 18v.

Arrears

Hugh de Wynterore, reeve, renders account for £10 6s 3½d from the arrears of Gilbert Forestar, reeve of the past year. Sum £10 6s 3½d.

Rent of assize

The same renders account for 10s 3d from rent at the term of the Invention of the Cross [3 May]. And for 111s 6½d from rent at the term of St Michael. Sum £6 21½d.

Acquittances and defects

Of which in acquittance of the reeve for 1 virgate of land for the year 3s. Likewise in defect for a certain house and land pertaining to the church drawn into demesne 20s. Likewise in defect for 1 rood of meadow formerly of Legarda atte Hulle in La Brodemede drawn into demesne 1d. Likewise in defect for 1 rood of meadow of Albreda atte Hulle drawn into demesne 1d. Sum 23s 2d.

\Sum of rent remaining £4 18s 7½d./

Rent of the hall of Kingston

The same renders account for 2s from rent of the hall of Kingston and not more because it was unroofed and broken down because none wanted to hire it, by witness of the bailiff. Sum 2s.

Issue of the manor

The same render account for 2d from pannage of John at Barre for 1 pig and 2 piglets. And for 2d received from Thomas atte Frith for 2 pigs from pannage called

⁴¹⁰ Goats were sold in 1326/7 and 1327/8 for 10d. each, presumably for meat: HRO, 11M59/B1/80-1.

'Garsanese'. And for 4s 9d received from pannage, outside,⁴¹¹ of pigs at Esher by customary acknowledgement sworn with Lord R de Beref as shown,⁴¹² by parcels. And for 6s 8d from pasture sold at Northwode for the year and not more because half was sown with oats. And for 8d received from the fishery there sold. And for 2s from pasture in Dounwode sold. From pasture in Bulbecombe and Longeforlong nothing because sown with oats. And for 8d from pasture of Hullemede sold. From pasture in La Frith which was usually sold for 6d, Churgrave which was usually sold for 6d, nothing this year because no buyer came, caused by the murrain of beasts.⁴¹³ And for 2s from pasture in La More sold. From pasture in La Crumbe nothing, protected by the bailiff for felling trees in the same. From pasture in the garden nothing this year because depastured by the lord's horses. And for 12d from pasture in the warren sold. And for 24s from 800 talwood⁴¹⁴ sold at Northwode, price of a hundred 3s. And for 16s from 1,200 faggots sold there, price of a hundred 16d. And for 12s from 11 old and weak trees in La Crumbe sold, by view of the bailiff. And for 21s from 700 talwood sold at Esher in La Crumb, price of a hundred 3s. From faggots there nothing because all were used by the lord. And for 6s from hay sold to Lord H le Despens Senior for three nights there.⁴¹⁵ And for 16d from one hide of a horse in murrain sold. And for 2s from the hide of 1 cow in murrain sold. And for 15d from 5 cocks and 5 hens from 'churchscot' sold. And for 18d from small withies of willow sold for a fish trap.⁴¹⁶ And for 3d from two pelts taken in murrain sold. And for 2d from one hide of a calf in murrain sold. And for 40s from hay sold to the lord. Sum £7 3s 7d.

Sales at the audit

And for 4½d from things sold at the audit. Sum 4½d.

Sale of corn

The same answers for 10d from 2 bushels of beans sold. Sum 10d.

Entry fines

The same renders account for 3s 4d from Emma who was the wife of Roger le Sopare for holding one messuage 2½ acres of land in Esher that were the said Roger, her husband's. And for 30s from Richard son of Richard le Hunte for having one tenement, 1 virgate of land at Woxford and half of one watermill there that were the aforesaid Richard, his father's, by surrender of the same Richard. And for 8s from tithingpenny for two tourns at Hockday. Sum 41s 4d.

Perquisites

The same renders account for 10s 3d from the perquisites of the tourn of St Martin with one court held before. And for 10s from the perquisites of the tourn of Hockday

⁴¹¹ That is, presumably, outside the bishop's enclosure.

⁴¹² A reference to a subsidiary document used in the drawing up of the original reeve's account.

⁴¹³ For analyses of the nature and impact of the cattle murrain see Slavin, 'Great Bovine Pestilence', and Newfield, 'Cattle panzootic'.

⁴¹⁴ Small logs.

⁴¹⁵ Hugh Despenser the Elder and his son, favourites of Edward II, were exiled in the summer of 1321.

⁴¹⁶ This entry perhaps suggests that Bishop Rigaud's sympathies lay with the king.

In MS, 'gurgit[e]'.
 1321.

with one court held before. And for 12d from one court held at Kingston. Sum 21s 3d. Sum of both 62s 7d.

Sum of all receipts \with arrears/ £25 14s 3½d.

Cost of ploughs

In making one plough from new, fitted with the lord's timber 6d. In fitting the same with a chip 1d. In one ploughshare bought 9d. In two plough feet bought 6d. In a contract made with one smith repairing and maintaining the ironwork of the aforesaid plough for three terms of the year from his own iron and steel 2s. In one pair of wheels bought for the plough 4d. In 32 herrings bought for 16 customary tenants of the lord harrowing the demesne land for one day at Lenten sowing 3d, namely to each of them two herrings by custom. In two harrows made from the lord's timber 4d. Sum 4s 9d.

Cost of carts

In one pair of bare wheels bought for the cart 2s 4d. In one body of a cart bought from new 12d. In clouts and nails bought for the same 8d. In grease and soap bought for greasing the cart 3d. In fitting the aforesaid cart with an axle 2d. In one saddle bought for the cart with a base for the same 7d. In two new collars bought 9d. In two pairs of traces bought 7d. In shoeing 4 cart horses and stots for three terms 3s. In one rope of hemp bought for the cart 8d. Sum 10s.

Purchase of corn

In 1 bushel of rye bought 9d. In 1 quarter 5 bushels of barley bought for seed 8s 8d, price of a bushel 8d. In 11 quarters 7½ bushels of barley bought for payment of the *famuli* 47s 9d, price of a quarter 4s. In 1 bushel of beans bought 5d. In 12 quarters 6 bushels of oats bought 21s 3d, price of a quarter 20d. Sum 78s 10d.

Purchase of stock

In 2 oxen bought by view of the bailiff 40s. In 1 horse bought for ploughing 10s. In 3 horses bought for carting and ploughing 47s. In another cart horse bought 18s. Sum 115s.

Cost of buildings

In one tiler hired with his boy for 12½ days to roof on the hall, the chapel, the grange, and other buildings in the *curia* at Esher 5s 2½d, taking for a day 5d. In mending one broken door to the wine cellar there 4d. In 2,000 tiles bought for mending defects on the hall, the chapel, the grange, and the stable as aforementioned 4s. In stipend of two carpenters for 3½ days for mending the fence between the bridge and the hall and one piece of the wall next to the chapel by piecework 2s 4d, taking for a day 8d. In stipend of the same for one day for repairing and mending a rack and a manger in the stable in preparation for the coming of the lord 8d. In 200 nails called standard nails⁴¹⁷ bought for the aforesaid work 4d. In 100 lath nails bought for the same ¾d. In stipend of one carpenter for two days repairing the broken walls of the grange at

⁴¹⁷ In MS, 'standisnail'.

Northwode 8d. In stipend of one roofer and his boy for four days for roofing on the grange and oxshed at Northwode 2s, taking for a day 6d. In making 1,500 talwood 7s 6d, for a hundred 6d. In making 1,200 faggots at Northwode 5s, for a hundred 5d. In making 300 faggots at Esher 15d, for a hundred 5d. Sum 29s 4¼d.

Cost of the fold

In 24 hurdles bought for the lord's fold 3s, price of a hurdle 1½d.⁴¹⁸

Weeding and mowing

In weeding all the demesne corn at Esher 8d. In weeding at Northwode 4d. In expenses of the lord's customary tenants mowing the meadow of La Brodemede: bread from stock; likewise in 1 wether with its pelt bought for an accompaniment for the same 12d; in cheese bought 3d. In mowing the meadow at Esher named Hullemede by piecework, with the meadow of La Lak next to Crumb, and the meadow of Legarda at Hulle, containing in all 3 acres, 18d, for an acre 6d. In spreading, turning, and pitching all the said hay 6d. In carriage of hay from La Brodemede: bread from stock; in herrings bought by custom 4d. In mowing, turning, and pitching one piece of meadow at Northwode by piecework, inclusively, containing 2½ acres, 15d. Sum 5s 10d.

Cost of harvest

In two boonworks of 44 men, each boon of 22 men, who reaped and bound all the demesne corn at Esher for two meals in a day: bread from stock; in 264 herrings bought for an accompaniment to the same 2s 2d, price of a hundred 10d, and each had in a day three herrings at noon and three herrings at dinner; in cheese bought for the aforesaid two boons 8d. In candles for all of harvest 1d. In reaping and binding 17 acres of oats at Northwode by piecework 7s 1d, for an acre 5d. In expenses of the reeve for harvest 2s. Sum 12s.

Foreign expenses

Indenture sealed for making one pillory and one cucking stool⁴¹⁹ from new by order of the bailiff, inclusively, 2s. In stipend of one carpenter making one pair of stocks⁴²⁰ 10d. In expenses of Lord Ralph de Bereford coming there for taking the tourn 4s 7d. In expenses of T de Folquardby for overseeing the manor and for marking oaks for selling for two days 3s 1d. Likewise in expenses of Lord R de Bereford and T de Folquardby for another visit 9½d. In expenses of Richard Clerk, bailiff of Esher, sent there and to Northwode by the lord bishop to meet and to answer various men coming from outside, so that they do not inflict damage or destruction in the said manor, for five days and for his coming for holding a court and overseeing the manor 13s 4d, by order of the lord. Sum 24s 7½d.

⁴¹⁸ No sum is given.

⁴¹⁹ In English in MS, 'shulvyngstol'. A cucking stool (a commode upon which a scold – and sometimes others accused of wrongdoing – was forcibly sat for public humiliation) should not be confused with the later ducking stool.

⁴²⁰ Again, in English, 'stockes'.

Cost of manuring

In expenses of 18 customary tenants carrying manure from the *curia* to La Cleye with nine carters and nine spreaders for six days 6s 9d, of which each had for a day $\frac{3}{4}$ d. Sum 6s 9d.

Threshing and winnowing

In threshing 1 quarter 2 bushels of rye $2\frac{1}{2}$ d. Likewise for threshing 2 bushels of beans $\frac{1}{2}$ d. In threshing 24 quarters 2 bushels of oats by piecework 18d, for a heaped quarter $\frac{3}{4}$ d. In winnowing all the corn 5d, for every 10 bushels $\frac{1}{4}$ d. Sum 2s 2d.

New fol. *Stipend of the famuli*

In stipend of one carter for two terms 2s. And for the term of St Michael 3s. Likewise in stipend of one ploughdriver for two terms 20d. And for the term of St Michael 2s 6d. Likewise in stipend of John le Vinour for two terms 20d and for the term of St Michael 2s 6d. In stipend of one goatherd for the term of St Michael 2s 6d. Sum 15s 10d.

Payment of rent

In payment to the abbot of Chertsey for the land of Northwode at the feast of St Michael 6s. Likewise in two ploughshares bought for payment to the same 18d. Sum 7s 6d.

Sum of all expenses £15 15s $7\frac{3}{4}$ d.

And he owes £9 18s $7\frac{3}{4}$ d.

It *Rye*

answers The same renders account for 1 quarter $2\frac{1}{2}$ bushels of rye received there from issue
×3. by tally against J atte Barre. And for 1 bushel bought. Sum 1 quarters $3\frac{1}{2}$ bushels. Of which in bread baked for expenses of the customary tenants mowing the lord's meadow 3 bushels. Likewise in expenses of the same carrying the lord's hay 1 bushel. In bread baked for the expenses of the customary tenants harrowing the lord's land 1 bushel. Likewise in expenses of the customary tenants at two harvest boonworks 6 bushels. And sold at the audit $\frac{1}{2}$ bushel for $4\frac{1}{2}$ d.

Beans

The same renders account for 2 bushels of beans received there from issue of one curtilage at Northwode planted beside the field. And for 1 bushel bought. Sum 3 bushels. Of which in expenses of 15 pigs coming from Farnham by letter of the constable 1 bushel, and sold.⁴²¹

It *Oats*

answers The same renders account for 24 quarters 2 bushels of small oats received there from
×2½ less issue by tally against John at Barre. And for 12 quarters 6 bushels bought. Sum 37
1 qu 3 bu. quarters. Of which in seed over 24 acres at Bulbecombe and Longforlong 12 quarters

⁴²¹ As indicated in the charge section of the account, above, the sale refers to the rest of the beans (2 bushels).

2 bushels, in an acre 4 bushels, plus in total 2 bushels. Likewise in seed over 6 acres in Ryhulle 3 quarters, over an acre $\frac{1}{2}$ quarter. Likewise in seed over 4 acres in La Cleye 2 quarters, over an acre $\frac{1}{2}$ quarter. Likewise in seed over 17 acres at Northwode 8 quarters 5 bushels, over an acre 4 bushels plus in total 1 bushel. And besides 8 quarters were sown for the third sheaf by John Prodomme.⁴²² In fodder for Lord Ralph de Beresford holding the tourn of St Martin 6 bushels. In expenses of the same and Lord Thomas de Folquardby for another visit there for various negotiations 4 bushels. In expenses of the said Thomas coming there for the sale of wood $2\frac{1}{2}$ bushels. In fodder for $\frac{1}{4}$ cart horses and stots from the feast of the Purification [2 February] until the eve of the Annunciation [24 March] for 49 nights 3 quarters $\frac{1}{2}$ bushel, taking for a night $\frac{1}{2}$ bushel. Likewise in fodder for the said horses from the said feast of the Annunciation [25 March] until the fourth day of May for 42 nights 5 quarters 2 bushels, taking for a night 1 bushel and so much this year because there were no oxen there. In flour for pottage for the *famuli* 1 quarter 2 bushels, each one taking each term 1 bushel.

Barley

The same renders account for 13 quarters $4\frac{1}{2}$ bushels of barley received from purchase. Of which in seed over 3 acres of land in La Cleye 1 quarter 5 bushels, over an acre 4 bushels, plus in total 1 bushel. Likewise in payment of one carter and ploughman from the feast of the Circumcision of the Lord [1 January] until the feast of St Michael for 39 weeks 3 quarters $7\frac{1}{2}$ bushels, taking a quarter for 10 weeks. In payment of John le Vinour from the said feast until the feast of St Michael 3 quarters 2 bushels, taking a quarter for 12 weeks. In payment of one ploughdriver from the 25th day of January until the feast of St Michael for 35 weeks $3\frac{1}{2}$ quarters, taking a quarter for 10 weeks. In payment of one boy guarding the lord's goats from the feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul [29 June] until the feast of St Michael for 13 weeks 1 quarter 2 bushels, taking a quarter for 10 weeks.

Stock

Horses

The same renders account for 2 cart horses bought. Sum 2. And 2 cart horses remain.

Affers

The same renders account for 3 affers bought. Of which in murrain around the first days of Lent [4 March] 1.⁴²³ And 2 affers remain.

Oxen

The same renders account for 2 oxen received from purchase. And 2 oxen remain.

⁴²² The third sheaf of the corn tithes from the demesne might be given to the vicar: Hartridge, *History of vicarages*, p. 45. John Prodomme held land at Northwode (see below, doc. 27), which lay within the parish of Cobham (the advowson for which was held by Chertsey Abbey) rather than the parish of Esher (which had a rector).

⁴²³ In MS, '*carniprivium*', which can also mean Septuagesima Sunday [15 February 1321] or Sexagesima Sunday [22 February 1321].

Cows

The same renders account for 1 cow received from the heriot of Roger le Sopere before calving. And in murrain 1. And none remain.

Calves

The same renders account for 1 calf received from the issue of the said cow. Sum 1. And accounted for in murrain. And none remain.

Buck goats

The same renders account for 4 buck goats received from Farnham. Sum 4. And 4 remain.

Male goats

The same renders account for 29 castrated goats received from Farnham. Sum 29. And all remain.

Doe goats

The same renders account for 82 doe goats received from Farnham. Sum 82. Of which in murrain 2 because of frequent harassing.⁴²⁴ Sum 2. And 80 doe goats remain.

Swans

The same renders account for 5 swans from a gift. Of which in murrain 2. Sent to Farnham by order of the lord \3/. And none remain.

Hens

The same renders account for 5 cocks and 5 hens owing from 'churchscot' at Christmas. And sold and none remain.

Verjuice

The same renders account for 10 gallons of verjuice⁴²⁵ from issue of the grapes this year. And for 12 gallons of verjuice made from crab apples. Sum 52 gallons. And all remains.

Cider

The same renders account for 70 gallons of cider from issue of the garden. And all remains.

Talwood

The same renders account for 800 talwood from rotten oak. And for 700 talwood from trees felled in La Crumbe at Esher by the direction of Thomas de Folquardby. Sum 1,500. And all were sold.

⁴²⁴ In MS, '*crebram vexac[i]o[n]em*'.

⁴²⁵ Judging by the total this should be '40', 'xl', rather than '10', 'x'.

Faggots

The same renders account for 1,200 faggots received at Northwode from the aforesaid felled oaks. And for 300 faggots at Esher from trees felled in La Crumbe. Sum 1,500. Of which in expenses of the lord for his coming there on the way towards the parliament of the lord king in London 300. And sold 1,200.

26. 29 September 1325 to 29 September 1326

Climatic change is often accompanied by extreme and changeable weather conditions and in the 1320s a new phase of weather conditions took hold, characterised not by torrential rain but by severe drought.⁴²⁶ Droughts had occurred in 1323 and 1325 but the author of the *Annales Paulini* – who was based in London – believed that the drought of 1326 was ‘unprecedented’.⁴²⁷ Indeed, in the Esher account for 1325/6, meadow at Northwode was not mown ‘since there was a drought at summer-time’; even the number of willow withies that were sold was reduced that year for the same reason. Drought could potentially affect agricultural fortunes and animal and human health in a numbers of ways. Certainly, tenants at Esher appear to have been sensitive to these conditions, especially given the cumulative impact of the problems of the preceding decade. In the three years 1324/5, 1325/6, and 1326/7 there was a sudden influx of heriots received, the contextual details of which are as telling as the numbers themselves. In this account, for example, we learn that the heriot paid after the (specified) death of Richard Walerond was merely a supertunic rather than an animal. Moreover, some of the holdings that were passed on were pathetically small: that which Nicholas le Creller inherited from his father, consisted only of a cottage with its curtilage and $\frac{1}{4}$ acre of land; notably, the next entry reveals that a heriot paid by the same family, presumably for this surrender, amounted to the value of a calf, rather than the calf itself. The account for 1325/6 is illuminating in two further ways. First, more prosaically, it contains an unusual amount of information about the organisation of the manorial landscape, not least with respect to the nature of Dounwode, the distinction between different areas of woodland, and the location of surviving vines. More remarkably, it also contains a reference to snakes, which appear to have taken up residence in the lord’s stable. Snakes, whether adders or grass snakes, may have been driven closer to human and animal habitation by the drought, though it is also possible that manure from the stable was being removed more assiduously than usual (given the lack of other livestock) and that a nest had been disturbed. A similar reference occurs in the account for 1329/30, when 18 customary tenants removed manure from the *curia* over the course of 22 days, ‘by order of the lord’, because ‘many snakes were discovered’ there.⁴²⁸ See Plates 3a and 3b for photos of the original account for 1325/6.

HRO, 11M59/B1/79, rot 36r, 36v.

⁴²⁶ For an analysis of the agricultural and demographic implications of drought in this period, see Stone, ‘Impact of drought’.

⁴²⁷ Stubbs, ed., *Chronicles*, I, pp. 312–13.

⁴²⁸ HRO, 11M59/B1/83.